

Crocodylus porosus

Saltwater crocodile



Length 16–23 ft (5–7 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia to N. Australia

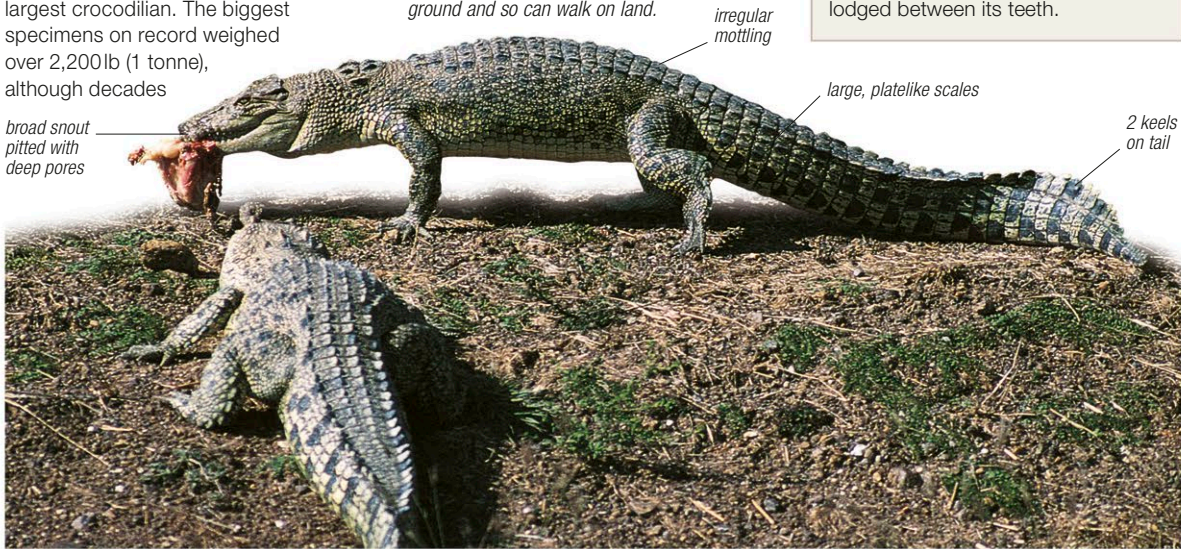


Also known as the estuarine or Indo-Pacific crocodile, this massive gray, brown, or black animal is the world's largest crocodilian. The biggest specimens on record weighed over 2,200 lb (1 tonne), although decades

of hunting mean that such giants are now very rare. Equally at home in freshwater and seawater, these nocturnal reptiles feed on a wide variety of animals, including mammals, birds, and fishes. They present a real threat to humans, and have been responsible for many fatalities. They mate in water, and the females lay about 60 eggs in mound nests on the river bank, high above the watermark. Each female guards her clutch, and stays with her hatchlings for the first few weeks of their life.

WALKING ON LAND

The saltwater crocodile has strong enough legs to raise its body off the ground and so can walk on land.



BASKING



The saltwater crocodile may haul itself onto a bank on hot days and bask with its mouth agape. Having its mouth open stops it from overheating, and it allows small birds to peck at parasites and bits of food lodged between its teeth.

Melanosuchus niger

Black caiman



Length 13–20 ft (4–6 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Lower risk

Location N. South America



Hunted for its skin, the black caiman has become extinct in many parts of its range, and its numbers are thought to have been reduced by 99 percent in the past 100 years. It has an almost parallel snout tapering sharply at the tip and gray bands on the lower jaw. It floats on the surface by day but may come ashore to feed at night. Fishes, waterbirds, capybara, the occasional domestic animal, and even humans may fall prey to it. The female lays and guards 30–65 eggs, and stays with the young after hatching.



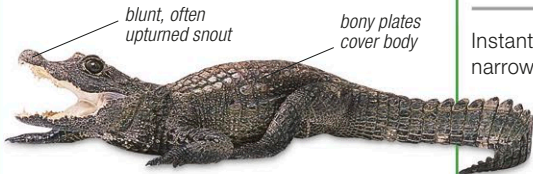
Osteolaemus tetraspis

Dwarf crocodile



Length 5½ ft (1.7 m), max 6¼ ft (1.9 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Vulnerable

Location W. and C. Africa



This relatively short, black crocodile lives in permanent pools and swamps in the African rain forest. It hides in burrows and among submerged tree roots during the day, and forages at the water's edge at night, taking its prey with a sideways snap of the jaws. In areas with seasonal flooding, fishes are the main food in the wet season, and crustaceans for the rest of the year. Frogs and toads are also eaten. The female lays usually 10 eggs in a mound of soil and vegetation, guards them, and protects her young in the water. This crocodile is probably common in some parts of its range, but in others, its numbers are depleted because of habitat destruction.

Gavialis gangeticus

Gharial



Length 13–23 ft (4–7 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Critically endangered

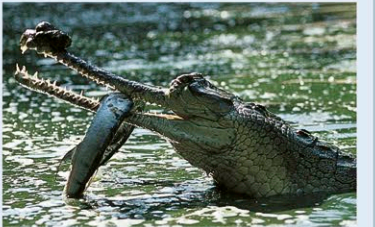
Location N. Indian subcontinent



Instantly recognizable by its unique narrow snout, the gharial—or gavial—is a large but slender crocodilian that spends most of its life in water. Compared to other crocodilians, its legs are relatively weak, and its feet are broadly webbed. Gharials feed primarily on fishes, although they also eat waterbirds. During the breeding season, the male becomes strongly territorial, and assembles a harem of females. The female excavates a nest well away from the water's edge, and lays up to 50 eggs, which at about 5 oz (150 g) each are unusually large. She protects the hatchlings, but does not carry them to water—probably because of the unsuitable shape of her jaws. The gharial almost became extinct in the 1970s as a result of habitat loss, hunting, and fishing; subsequent captive breeding has only had limited success.

A MULTIFUNCTIONAL SNOOT

The gharial's long, slender snout may look fragile, but it is armed with small, extremely sharp teeth. It catches fishes sideways, and then flicks them within its jaws so that it can swallow them head first. The bulbous growth at the end of the nose is present only in males, and is used to produce sounds and bubbles during courtship.



LIFE IN WATER

The highly aquatic gharial inhabits slow-moving backwaters of large rivers, leaving the water only to bask on mud or sandbanks, and to lay eggs. It submerges itself in deep water for safety. Mating, too, takes place in water. The gharial has poorly developed legs and is unable to walk on land, barely managing to push itself over the mud.

